Trade and Empire

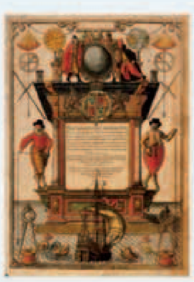
Between the late 15th and 18th centuries, many European nations developed large trading empires stretching to Africa, Asia, and the Americas. Imperial growth tended to follow one of two patterns—centralized, bureaucratic, and monarchical, or mercantile and occasionally chaotic.

BEFORE

Advances in navigation opened new doors.

EXIT THE DRAGON

In 1405–33, seven major Chinese naval expeditions explored and traded across the oceans as far west as Africa. Chinese trade and empire could have been carried farther, but the project was abandoned—largely due to imperial mistrust of foreigners.



MARINER'S MIRROUR 1588

NAVIGATION AIDS

From the 15th century onward, improvements to maps and navigation manuals allowed European sailors to venture across the world's oceans. *Mariner's Mirrour* was the first book to show standardized symbols for buoys, channels, safe anchorages, and submerged rocks.

Spain, Portugal, and France were nations under the rule of autocratic monarchs and their courtiers. Any overseas trade was firmly tied to royal finances.

The Portuguese established the pattern for empire-building: within 15 years of their arrival in the Indian Ocean in the 1480s, they had destroyed Arab naval power. Portugal had limited population and natural resources, but a wealth of nautical and navigational expertise. By forging an empire, it could tap into the lucrative Asian spice trade, giving it greater financial security. Bases at Malacca, Ormuz, and Goa in the Indian Ocean, established by Portuguese navy general Afonso da Albuquerque, ensured control of the Persian Gulf and major spice trade routes to the east. Macau, in Southern China, followed in 1517, and by the 1560s, Portugal imported 50 percent of Europe's spice supply and 75 percent of its pepper. At the same time, the Portuguese were importing the first African slaves to Brazil (see pp.280–81), ensuring that the colony became the world's largest sugar producer.

> "Let it be known that if you are **strong in ships** the commerce of **the Indies is yours**."
>
> FRANCISCO DE ALMEIDA, FIRST PORTUGUESE VICEROY OF INDIA, *c.* 1507

Between 1580 and 1640, Portugal and Spain operated their empires in parallel under the king of Spain. Spain's trade bureaucracy ensured that the monarch received 20 percent of all precious metals mined in the New World, in exchange for protective convoys. New colonies in the Philippines ensured a transit point between America and China, while Portugal helped Spain dominate East Asian trade, carrying gold and silver to China and bringing back silk via the Pacific and Atlantic oceans.

It was the mercantile commercial philosophy of the French Richelieu and later Colbert that drove France's colonial ambitions under Louis XIV (see pp.278–79). France's empire was a state creation, and at first excited little enthusiasm among the French merchant classes. One notable exception was the fur trade created in New France (Canada), along the trading network around the Great Lakes.

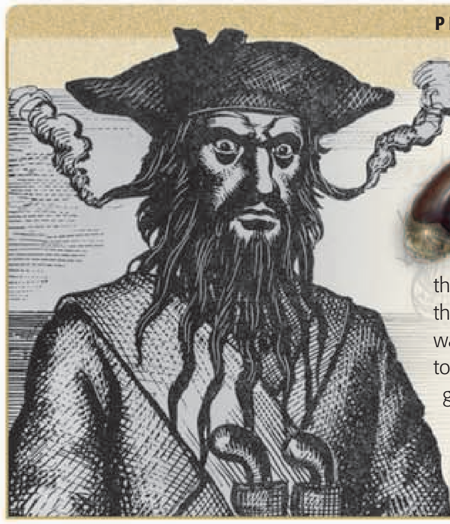
Trade for France's rulers, as for Spain's, meant reaping the benefits of colonial resources in order to safeguard a position in Europe. In both countries, the interests of merchants themselves came a poor second.

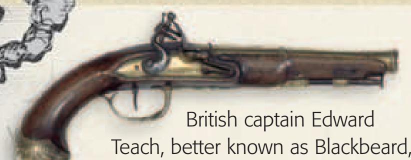
Empires of merchants

Traders and adventurers were at the forefront of England and Holland's "private-enterprise" empires. Both

PIRATE (*c.* 1680–1718)

EDWARD TEACH





British captain Edward Teach, better known as Blackbeard, was a notorious pirate, operating along the coast of Virginia, the Carolinas, and throughout the Caribbean in his 40-gun warship *Queen Anne's Revenge*. He seized tolls from ships with the backing of the governor of North Carolina, until a British force was dispatched at the request of cotton planters. He was attacked and decapitated in November 1718.

Wampum fur trade belt

Belts of small seashells, called wampums, were made by Iroquois natives along the New England coast. Dutch traders used wampum beads as currency in the fur trade with the Iroquois from the early 1600s.